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From Postcolonialism to Cosmopolitanism: Reading Timothy Mo's Thematic Shift and Its Resonance with the Development of British Chinese Literature

Yifan Jin

Department of Chinese (Zhuhai), Sun Yat-sen University, Zhuhai, People's Republic of China

ABSTRACT
Timothy Mo, a popular postcolonial author in late twentieth-century British literature, has written extensively about Hong Kong. However, his later and more cosmopolitan works about subjects outside his motherland and adopted country are less acknowledged, let alone his relevant role in British Chinese literature. While Mo's early career was marked by a distinct "Chineseness", his later writing gradually shifted focus to multi-displaced Asian diasporas that could not be assigned to any nation-state or ethnic group and shared a deterritorialised identity. This article examines Mo's oeuvre and argues that his negotiations with "Chineseness" and cosmopolitanism are consistent with British Chinese literature's move towards a radical world literature. The integration of Mo's thematic shift with this developing literary field reveals not only the heterogeneity of UK-published writers of Chinese descent but also an anti-essentialist approach to ethnic minorities' literary identities.

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Timothy Mo; British Chinese literature; postcolonial British literature; cosmopolitan writing; Asian diasporas; ethnic minorities

Timothy Mo is among the most outstanding minority novelists in post-World War II British literature, distinguished by the breadth of his seven novels, which span diverse communities—including Cantonese Hong Kongers, the overseas Chinese, and Southeast Asians. Mo was initially known for his "postcolonial fictions" set in Hong Kong, and was recognised as one of only two British authors of Chinese descent mentioned in *The Cambridge History of Twentieth-Century English Literature* (2004).[1] His first four novels, *The Monkey King* (1978), *Sour Sweet* (1982), *An Insular Possession* (1986), and *The Redundancy of Courage* (1991), have won several awards in English literary circles. These works present the encounter between Western and Chinese cultures, with the latter gaining much attention, "add[ing] an ethnic Chinese contour to the new literary map of British fiction".[2] In early studies, Anglophone researchers focused on his portrayal of Confucianism, xenophobia, and pragmatism through Chinese characters, and their connection with the contested notion of "Chineseness",[3] whereas Sinophone scholars

CONTACT Yifan Jin jyifangrace@gmail.com

[1]Woods, "Postcolonial Fictions," 745.
[2]Ho, *Timothy Mo*, 2.
[3]See Rothfork, "Confucianism in Timothy Mo's *Sour Sweet*"; Ramraj, "Timothy Mo"; Wijesinha, "Timothy Mo's *The Redundancy of Courage*"; Lim, "Race, National Identity, and the Subject in the Novels of Timothy Mo."

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criticised him for alienating Chinese culture.[4] This tension marks Mo's in-betweenness, a position that coincided with the late twentieth-century recognition of "British Chinese" as a notable presence, when cultural practitioners of Chinese descent who had been born after the war and lived in the UK entered academic discourse.[5]

Mo did not make the most of his postcolonial bonus, as he parted ways with Random House, returned to the East, and led an itinerant life between Hong Kong, the Philippines, and Thailand, in the latter two of which he has set his last three novels. *Brownout on Breadfruit Boulevard* (1995) and *Renegade or Halo*^{2} (1999) were published by his own Paddleless Press, whereas *Pure* (2012) was published by a London-based distribution company named Turnaround Books. Their limited marketing and circulation once led to a lukewarm reception in the Anglosphere as well as in China, partly because they lacked conventionally "Chinese" elements. Nevertheless, as the category of "Chinese" in Britain is increasingly perceived as "by no means a homogeneous ethnic group",[6] recent scholarship has turned its focus to Mo's shifting references to Chinese culture.[7] Moreover, the contemporary questioning of the dominance of the term "British Chinese" over other British East and Southeast Asian identities[8] parallels Mo's second relocation, as well as sporadic engagement with his narrative transformation to the Philippines and Thailand.[9] Correspondingly, his later three works have gradually attracted critical interest in a cosmopolitan consciousness that resists the confines of essentialist identity frames.[10] This renewed attention brings into view his contribution not only to the heterogenisation of "British Chinese" literary identity but also to the articulation of (Southeast) Asian voices within international English-language literature.

Despite continuous discussions of Mo's single works, there is little research on his oeuvre, and specifically, on the logic behind his thematic shift. The subject matter of Mo's literary productions can be divided into three dimensions: the ambiguous Chineseness resulting from his identity anxiety, metafictional narratives related to his expertise in history, and a nonexclusive subjectivity accompanying his embrace of cosmopolitanism. The arc of his writing career illustrates, to some extent, the century-long, tripartite development of British Chinese literature:[11] while his creative portrayal of Hong Kong resonates with the nostalgia characteristic of its embryonic stage, his thematic shift to spaces outside the literature's titular binary constrains correspond with its subsequent

[4]Ruan, Zhang, and Li, *Yingguo Kuawenhua Xiaozhuo Zhong De Shenfen Cuoluan*.

[5]Yeh, "The Cultural Politics of In/Visibility," 31. In addition to Mo, Yeh explores a range of other British Chinese figures, including writers Graham Chan and Jung Chang, visual artists Erika Tan and Leilei Qu, and performers Pui Fan Lee and Anna Chen.

[6]Luk, *Chinatown in Britain*, 209.

[7]See McMahon, "Postmodernism in Bamboo Scaffolding"; Vandertop, "Floating Cities, Imperial Bodies"; Liu, "Where did Timothy Mo Go?"; Tse, "English-Language Literature of Hong Kong."

[8]Yeh, "The Cultural Politics of In/Visibility," 50.

[9]See Hedman and Sidel, *Philippine Politics and Society in the Twentieth Century*; Stapleton, *Thailand*, 192; Sykes, *Imagining Manila*.

[10]See Spencer, *Cosmopolitan Criticism and Postcolonial Literature*; Cheah, *What Is a World?*; Sykes, *Imagining Manila*; Hu, "Memory Writing and Cosmopolitan Identity"; Hu and Ni, "Cosmopolitan Ideal in Timothy Mo's *An Insular Possession*."

[11]British Chinese literature, which originated in the early twentieth century, is often periodized into three stages, loosely demarcated by shifting geopolitics surrounding the rise and fall of the Cold War. Representative works include, among others, Shih-I Hsiung's *Lady Precious Stream* (1934), Yee Chiang's *The Silent Traveller* (1937), and Chun-Chan Yeh's *The Ignorant and the Forgotten* (1946) in the first stage; Dymia Hsiung's *Flowering Exile* (1952), Li Yuan-Chia's poetic manuscripts from the 1960s and 1970s, Timothy Mo's *Sour Sweet* (1982), and Jung Chang's *Wild Swans* (1991) in the second; and Hong Liu's *Startling Moon* (2001), Xiaolu Guo's *A Concise Chinese-English Dictionary for Lovers* (2007), Helen Tse's *Sweet Mandarin* (2007) and PP Wong's *The Life of a Banana* (2014) in the third.

flourishing and branching out, breaking free from national and ethnic territorialisation. On the one hand, all of Mo's protagonists, though situated in various times and places, struggle between a domesticating English ideology and competing (more than Chinese) cultural values, transcending boundaries between histories, languages, races, genders, and classes. On the other hand, Mo's transcultural writing, spanning over decades, traces the evolving identity of a diasporic author moving beyond the self-versus-other logic. This trajectory thus reflects his dynamic engagement with the constantly contested and negotiated field of British Chinese literature, consistent with its inexorable trend towards de-hyphenation and worldlisation.

Given Mo's shifting position and uneasy relationship with the global book market, he emerges as one of the first among his peers to interrogate ethnic labelling. His biracial background lends legitimacy to his questioning of being defined as exclusively either "Chinese" or "British", categories that had likely circumscribed his writing within enclosed, fixed understandings of belonging. This study reads Mo's emergence and progressive transformation as a continuous process, in which he deterritorialises Chineseness through negotiations with British multiculturalism, accounts for the performativity of "British Chinese", and gradually moves towards a more inclusive articulation of Asian subjectivity. By systematically examining his career trajectory from postcolonial to cosmopolitan engagement, this article argues that the evolution of Mo's writing is driven by a deterritorialisation of identity, which goes beyond the frameworks of nation-state and ethnicity, while maintaining an open dialogue with the dynamics of British Chinese literature. This makes Mo both a participant in and witness to the thematic diversity within this literary field and its move towards a radical world literature, thereby advancing a counter-stereotypical approach to the English-language literature perceived as "Chinese" and promoting a more equal treatment of majority and minority cultural discourses.

Deterritorialising Chineseness

> I know nothing about Chinese culture. It is as hard for me to write about things Chinese as it must have been for Paul Scott or J.G. Farrell to write about India. I'm a Brit.[12]

Though widely used as a cultural label, "Chineseness" is not a historically fixed or orthodox notion, but rather a product of ongoing identity work since modern times.[13] Its conceptualisation constitutes a dynamic and contested process of sense-making, particularly following the 1949 establishment of the communist regime in mainland China, which intensified disputes over the authority to define Chineseness. Tu Wei-ming's concept of "cultural China" redefines the periphery as the centre, allowing the overseas Chinese the possibility of "assum[ing] an effective role in creatively constructing a new vision of Chineseness that is more in tune with Chinese history and sympathetic resonance with Chinese culture".[14] Shu-mei Shih also emphasises that Sinophone voices have been "minoritised" within geopolitical China, and characterises Chineseness in relation to Chinese diasporas who use a range of Sinitic languages, far more diverse

[12]Hughes-Hallett, "A Singular Obsession," 150.
[13]Wang, "The Study of Chinese Identities in Southeast Asia," 1–2.
[14]Tu, "Cultural China," 28.

than what the Mandarin-centred view recognises.[15] Meanwhile, Rey Chow questions "the essentially external status of Chinese as an ethnic qualifier", whether invoked by the nation-state or by the periphery-centre binarism, and regards "Chineseness as the distinguishing trait in what otherwise purport to be mobile, international practices".[16] Aligning with the view that the concept is fluid, Ien Ang further posits it as "an open and indeterminate signifier whose meanings are constantly renegotiated and rearticulated in different sections of the Chinese diaspora".[17] This suggests that Chineseness should not serve as a "prisonhouse" confining individual subjects, but rather as a point of departure for their participation, as "citizens of the world"—in the ongoing cultural-political construction of global futures.[18] The open conceptualisation sheds light on the often interconnected and, at times, contrasting values embedded in Mo's portrayal of characters of Chinese descent, through which his refusal, ambivalence, and transcendence of this ethnic identity unfold as a process of the deterritorialisation of Chineseness.

Despite identifying himself as a British novelist and asserting that "[he] do[es]n't have a problem with that",[19] Mo explores Chinese culture from various diasporic perspectives in his early literary career, highlighting its multiple facets. This disjunction between self-identification and thematic orientation not only offers a wry response to the multicultural pursuit of "ethnicity" but also reflects Mo's dual consciousness as a biracial British Chinese writer. The tradition of what is now called British Chinese literature dates back to the early twentieth century, when the Boxer Protocol (1901) catalysed the institutionalisation of overseas study for Chinese intellectuals. During this period, authors such as Shih-I Hsiung and Yee Chiang who came to Britain presented their culture in ways that differentiated it from imagined Orientalist stereotypes, thereby making Chineseness more intelligible and acceptable in the Anglosphere. Regrettably, this quest for similarities, rather than peculiarities, was short-lived, as very few mainland Chinese successfully crossed the Bamboo and Iron Curtain during the Cold War. Until the end of the twentieth century, the UK's Chinese community largely consisted of Hong Kong immigrants, many of whom had obtained legal residence through the British Nationality Act of 1948,[20] enacted to tackle the post-war labour shortage. Consequently, Hong Kong, although peripheral to Chinese authorities, served as a bridge in British Chinese cultural communication. In Mo's first three novels, it is similarly cast as the embodiment of Chineseness and functions as a cultural intermediary amid the faint presence of Chinese voices in British literature.

Named after the reluctant convert to Buddhism in the Chinese classic *Journey to the West*, *The Monkey King* transforms the protagonist into Wallace Nolasco, a Chinese Portuguese born in Macau, who establishes matrilocal residence and lives in the Poon family, an emergent business family in post-war Hong Kong. The portrait of the Chinese family recurs in *Sour Sweet*, albeit in a different setting of contemporaneous London; its title, the

[15]Shih, "Theory, Asia and the Sinophone," 467.
[16]Chow, "On Chineseness as a Theoretical Problem," 23, 3.
[17]Ang, "Can One Say No to Chineseness?" 225; Ang, "To Be or Not to Be Chinese," 13.
[18]Ang, "Can One Say No to Chineseness?" 241, 242.
[19]Lim and Mo, "A Conversation with Timothy Mo," 561.
[20]Owen, *Chinese People and "Other" Ethnic Minorities in Great Britain*, 2. According to the 1991 UK Census of Population, nearly half of all foreign-born individuals in the Chinese ethnic group came from Hong Kong (47.6%), followed by the People's Republic of China (16.5%), Malaysia (13.5%), Vietnam (8.4%), Singapore (4.3%), Taiwan (1.5%), Mauritius (1.3%), and other countries (1.4%).

typical flavour of Westernised Chinese cuisine, signifies the mixed feelings of the Chens, who migrated from the New Territories to earn a living through catering. Wallace's biraciality and the Chens' dislocation retain Chineseness in non-local contexts, where Mo's de-authoritative approach demonstrates its performed and constructed nature. Within both the white world and its margins, the characters' paradoxical positioning enables a negotiation with British colonial discourse, illustrating minority writers' "multiple deterritorializations with language" across established literary genres.[21] Both the Poons and Chens speak Chinese Pidgin English (CPE), in contrast to the omniscient narrators' Standard English. However, they are the main characters who use the English language to defy the authority of native speakers, differing from British comic norms that portray foreigners with non-Standard English as being clownish. This reflects "the tension between the abrogation of the received English which speaks from the centre, and the act of appropriation which brings it under the influence of a vernacular tongue".[22] Thus, Mo mobilises Hong Kong—as Chineseness incarnate—to "write back" to the Empire, in concert with contemporary postcolonial authors' articulations of "imaginary homelands",[23] interrogating colonial legacies and challenging the conventions of English literary tradition. This strategy not only casts Hong Kong as a medium for mainstream understanding of minority experiences but also opens up a negotiable space for the practice of being Chinese.

Figured as a modern Monkey King and a Eurasian double of Mo himself, Wallace embodies the psychological tensions of dual identity and cultural in-betweenness, mirroring Mo's struggles as a newcomer to the literary world. While Wallace takes pride in his Caucasian heritage, symbolised by "the dimpled cleft in his chin", he expresses disdain for the living habits, cultural rituals, and social hierarchies of his Cantonese neighbours, which nonetheless shape his own daily life, reducing them to a caricature of "decadent [...] Chinkiness".[24] Such contrasting attitudes appear to echo the Orientalist positioning of the Chinese as subordinate to Western superiority—if not for the juxtaposition of similarly caustic remarks about the English and Americans, described respectively as "a nation of crafty hypocrites" and their "more straightforward cousins".[25] The equal stereotyping of different identities helps defuse Wallace's estrangement from Chinese culture and, in line with Mo's self-declaration, constitutes a "satirist's defence"[26] or "comedy of cultures"[27] regarding the "Chinese" label attached to him by mainstream society.

Meanwhile, Wallace's status as the Poons' son-in-law, binding his personal fate to a local Cantonese family, marks a destined deepening of his entanglement with Chineseness, just as it conceptually resists complete enclosure or separation, especially within a diasporic condition characterised by cultural hybridity. Through his progress from

[21]Deleuze and Guattari, *Kafka*, 18–19.
[22]Ashcroft, Griffiths, and Tiffin, *The Empire Writes Back*, 38.
[23]Rushdie, *Imaginary Homelands*, 10. For Mo's contemporaries in the 1970s and 1980s, see Buchi Emecheta and Ben Okri from Africa, V. S. Naipaul and Caryl Phillips from the West Indies, and Hanif Kureishi and Salman Rushdie from the Indian subcontinent.
[24]Mo, *The Monkey King*, 6.
[25]Ibid., 5.
[26]Ho, *Timothy Mo*, 13.
[27]Lai, *Asian English Writers of Chinese Origin*, 59.

being an "additional mouth"[28] to a family member whom Mr. Poon can "depend on",[29] Wallace unwittingly collaborates with the traditional Chinese sociocultural order that he previously despised. This ambiguity is ultimately condensed in his grotesque dream of attending a family feast, where the main delicacy is a young, living monkey. Despite sitting in "the place of honour",[30] Wallace empathises with the monkey, as the "hammer-head [...] came down in a silver blur".[31] This exaggerated scene manifests a problematic handling of Chineseness. By evoking the infamous "chilled monkey brains" dish featured in *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom* (1984), it humourises a broader trope that portrays exotic foods or other "Far East" customs for shock value. Through his ingenious response to Orientalist discourse, Mo not only echoes the critique of an antique, alienated Chineseness but also invites reflection on its layered legacies in a globalised cultural landscape.

In *Sour Sweet*, Chineseness is expressed through a more internalised and nuanced perspective, as members of the Chen family navigate different modes of living in the diaspora. Although Chen has acquired a certain level of English, he remains reluctant to interact with the locals because of "his foreignness";[32] he engages only when necessary for business, and even then, he focuses on the "various idiosyncrasies" of his customers.[33] His deliberate distinction between self and other ties him to a sense of Chineseness characteristic of ethnic ghettos, preventing his adaptation to British life. Indulging in "modern Cantonese dramas" in Chinatown,[34] Chen considers Hong Kong his only home and conveys this idea to the next generation:

> "Do you see the ship, Son?" he asked softly. "It is a special little ship for people like us, Son. [...] It is the ship that will take us all back home when we are finished here. It will take you to your homeland, Son, which you have never seen."[35]

For Chen, who ultimately dies in London, Hong Kong is equivalent to an "imaginary homeland". This reproduces "the 'diasporic formula' of a return to some putative 'homeland'",[36] particularly among first-generation Chinese immigrants, who cling to Chineseness as an emotional symbol to cope with feelings of nostalgia.

By comparison, Lily, Chen's wife, intended to be friendly to her customers but has since grown used to their indifference and rudeness, gradually becoming convinced that "Chinese people were superior to the foreign devils".[37] This ethnocentric turn illustrates a diasporic condition in which identification with Chineseness is markedly intensified through a form of cultural exclusion. Lily's ambivalent identity is embodied in the contrasting tones of her speech: "Her voice, so expressive and alive in her native Cantonese, became shrill, peremptory, and strangely lifeless in its level pitching when she spoke English. She would have sounded hostile and nervous."[38] The strangeness of her English,

[28]Mo, *The Monkey King*, 11.
[29]Ibid., 96.
[30]Ibid., 254.
[31]Ibid., 255.
[32]Mo, *Sour Sweet*, 13.
[33]Ibid., 34.
[34]Ibid., 34.
[35]Ibid., 162.
[36]Madsen, "Diaspora, Sojourn, Migration," 46.
[37]Mo, *Sour Sweet*, 143.
[38]Ibid., 141.

while echoing the previously discussed function of CPE as a means of "writing back", foregrounds the structural difficulties ethnic minorities face in integrating into British society. This mutual non-recognition is dramatised in Lily's restaurant, where "[s]he and the customers ignored each other; they couldn't even look one another in the eye. Each regarded the other as a non-person".[39] As the Chen family represents one of the most familiar portraits of Hong Kong Chinese in the catering business, their predicament indicates the notion of "parallel lives" fostered by multiculturalism,[40] in which different groups tend to assert labelled ethnic identities rather than engaging with cultural complexities that underlie those identities.

Indeed, depicting disparate cultural traits and sociopolitical environments—implicit in what Graham Huggan calls "strategic exoticism"[41]—meets the mainstream expectation of "the familiar aura of [the] other"[42] and provides ethnic minority writers with an important means of multicultural marketing. Nevertheless, through the exoticist codes, postcolonial authors are also capable of "inhabiting them to criticize them", or "redeploying them [to] uncover differential relations of power".[43] While the alienated representations of ethnic things in *The Monkey King* and *Sour Sweet* conduct ongoing negotiations with the global publishing industry, Mo's humorous, and even somewhat ironic depiction deterritorialises the affiliation of Chineseness with both the quest for authentic knowledge about China and the market's preference for the subordinate other. Thus, the variations of Chineseness in the two works point to its constructed, rather than essential, nature across racial, national, and ethnic boundaries. This deterritorialised approach not only moves beyond both geopolitical and cultural China but also illuminates the trajectory of Chineseness's modernisation and its constituent generations as reflected in British Chinese literature.

Cosmopolitanising "British Chinese"

> I believe that a novelist should pursue self-renewal through different creations. [...] In my own writing, I try my best to change, to create what's new. I could have written more books in the past fifteen years, but I have chosen to break new paths every time.[44]

The rise of British Chinese literature is inseparable from the contemporaneous emergence of what is now described as modern Chinese cosmopolitanism, an intellectual orientation premised on "an expansive knowledge constituted primarily by [an individual's] understanding of the world".[45] Yet this early cosmopolitanism was shaped by an asymmetrical relationship structured around a Western-dominated worldview. Driven by a desire to redress this imbalance, British Chinese literature has long envisioned more reciprocal forms of cultural interaction between China and the West. This intellectual and aesthetic stance of openness towards other cultural experiences persists in the later conceptualisation of "British Chinese" under the auspices of multiculturalism in the 1980s and 1990s. As the term's boundaries have remained "highly contested and its

[39]Ibid., 142.
[40]Cantle, *Community Cohesion*.
[41]Huggan, *The Postcolonial Exotic*, xi.
[42]Ibid., 37.
[43]Ibid., 32.
[44]Shu, "Zhixiang Qu Lvxing [I Only Want to Travel]," 22. The original interview was recorded in Chinese and the quotation has been self-translated by the article's author.
[45]Shih, *The Lure of the Modern*, 47.

meanings disputed",[46] it reflects an effort to acknowledge the diverse backgrounds of ethnic Chinese in Britain. The coexistence of both resistance to and acceptance of being encompassed by the term points to its inclusive potential.[47] Treating Mo as an exceptional literary case of "British Chinese"[48] is not meant to impose a hyphenated or circumscribed identity on his writing, but to bring the cosmopolitan ideal of this formulation into dialogue with the deterritorialisation of his dual ethnic and national affiliations. Building on this, "British Chinese" is cosmopolitanised in terms of its "attitudinal or dispositional orientation" and "mode of practice or competence" that are "culturally anti-essentialist".[49]

Aligning with British Chinese literature in articulating a mode of being-in-the-world beyond the universalist ethics of the Occidental paradigm, Mo's writing proposes "an alternative worldly ethics" and opens up "a richer and more complex sense of the world".[50] According to Pheng Cheah, the world should be understood "not only as a spatio-geographical entity but also as an ongoing dynamic process of becoming, something that possesses a historical-temporal dimension and hence is continually being made and remade".[51] This worldview of creation is embodied in Mo's ever-expanding diasporic map, reflected in his shifted attention to precolonial Hong Kong and independent East Timor. They not only negotiate the ethnic boundaries shaped by varied manifestations of Chineseness, but also call for an inquiry into the colonial discourses underpinning the equally umbrella-like concept of British identity, leaving unresolved the challenges involved in navigating decolonised subjectivity in an Asian context. Mo's subsequent writings, which resist both cultural imperialism and ethnocentrism, as Robert Spencer observes, "demonstrate (as opposed to merely announce the need for) an alternative form of postcolonial literary criticism that fosters self-criticism without sacrificing the possibility of knowledge, communication and even corrective".[52] In this sense, situating Mo's boundary-crossing literary practice regarding British Chinese literature's progression towards a decentred and generative world literature helps illuminate their shared evolving cosmopolitan identity, "constructed on a world scale rather than on the basis of regional, territorially limited states".[53]

In *An Insular Possession*, Mo goes beyond domestic chronicles and "change[s] direction"[54] to his professional field, tracing Hong Kong's hidden colonial history and preludes its upcoming postcolonial era. Through editions of two newspapers, the novel represents the tension between the hypocrisy of colonial discourses and the questioning of imperialist meta-narratives within the nineteenth-century global order. *The Canton Monitor* is run on behalf of the colonialist machine, reproducing the mainstream Anglophone view that the British trading opium and the First Opium War in the nineteenth century were the impetus for China's development:[55]

[46]Thorpe and Yeh, "Contesting British Chinese Culture," 4.
[47]While the dominance of "Chinese" over other East and Southeast Asian identities in British society in under question, writers such as Helen Tse and PP Wong—born into families from Hong Kong and Singapore—readily identify as "British Chinese".
[48]Yeh, "Contested Belongings," 300.
[49]Vertovec and Cohen, "Conceiving Cosmopolitanism," 9, 4.
[50]Cheah, *What Is a World?*, 324, 192.
[51]Ibid., 42.
[52]Spencer, *Cosmopolitan Criticism and Postcolonial Literature*, 166.
[53]Waldron, "What is Cosmopolitan?" 228.
[54]Lim and Mo, "A Conversation with Timothy Mo," 567.
[55]Fay, *The Opium War*, xvii; Lovell, *The Opium War*, 242.

> The price of progress can never be cheap. [...] It cannot be supposed that the Chinese, in their arrogance and false conviction of superiority, should for a moment imagine that the detested foreigner shall provide the occasion and means of their own betterment.[56]

In contrast, *The Lin Tin Bulletin and River Bee*, cofounded by two American sojourners Gideon Chase and Walter Eastman, usually have opinions contrary to the former's reportage of "truths", as the idealist Gideon claims in public: "Is it right, though, Ridley, that we should force the Chinese to trade with us when it is not their wish?"[57] The subversive voice of unofficial publications echoes postcolonial rewriting of the canon, which itself, as Fredric Jameson illuminates, may be seen as the "restructuration of a prior historical or ideological subtext",[58] that is, as a defence of hegemonic colonisation. While the novel's engagement with, parody of, or deconstruction of history has been a focus of scholarly attention,[59] its narrative divergence enables Gideon to develop an alternative perspective.

With a third-party narrative stemming from his American background, Gideon's Anglo-American affinity and his acquisition of Chinese endow him with a cosmopolitan vision "against the scenario of national ideologies linking language, literature, culture, and territory in one homogeneous whole".[60] Intended to facilitate transcultural communication, Gideon was reluctantly exploited as the conspirator of the act of aggression, as he served as the translator for a proclamation issued by the British Land Forces. Although claiming that "[i]t is not the intention of General Gough or the officers and men under his command to cause needless destruction to life and property at Canton",[61] the troops attacked unprotected local residents. Gideon's awkward position as a supposed conspirator of the act of aggression lies in the neglect of the broader colonial power structure, which was built more on decisive military and economic dominance than on indirect ideological or cultural influence. As Walter Mignolo argues, the realisation of decolonial cosmopolitanism entails "multiple trajectories aiming at a trans-modern world based on pluriversality rather than on a new and good universal for all".[62] While such a cosmopolitan ideal remains forward-looking yet unattainable in Gideon's era, his subtle entanglement with both Britain and China, further complicated by his American identity, resonates with the emerging de-dualisation of the "British Chinese" conception, an evolution that is instantiated in Mo's own literary trajectory.

The Redundancy of Courage develops Mo's wide-ranging themes, substituting the postcolonial centre-periphery model with a boundary-crossing world marked by cultural hybridity. The first-person narrator, Adolph Ng, a citizen of Danu, was born and raised in a local Chinese merchant family, received secondary and higher education in Macau and Toronto, and came back to take over the family business. His multiple displacements account for his status as "a citizen of the great world", and even as "a misfit for ever",[63]

[56]Mo, *An Insular Possession*, 413.
[57]Ibid., 26.
[58]Jameson, *The Political Unconscious*, 83.
[59]McLeod, "On the Chase for Gideon Nye," 61–2.
[60]Mignolo, *Local Histories/Global Designs*, 219.
[61]Mo, *An Insular Possession*, 584.
[62]Mignolo, "Cosmopolitanism and the De-colonial Option," 111.
[63]Mo, *The Redundancy of Courage*, 30.

especially upon his return, which forces him to renegotiate the terms not only of his nationality but also of his sensuality. Although Ng has little contact with the diasporic Chinese community, he attributes his affiliations with different political forces to what he self-mockingly calls "Chinese pragmatism".[64] In other words, Ng breaks Chen's diasporic formula of returning by shifting the focus from "where they are from" to "where they are". His seemingly paradoxical identity agrees with Stuart Hall's view of identity as a "production" in process, rather than an "already accomplished fact".[65] Hence, Ng's recognition of Chineseness is deterritorialised from both physical appearance and cultural heritage, enabling his survival in variously complicated environments; for him, "home" has no boundaries, as it exists within the self. A comparison of Chen's and Ng's self-identities demonstrates Mo's inhomogeneous portrayal of being Chinese. This trajectory highlights the increasingly mobile notion of "home" for members of the Chinese diaspora—extending beyond those identified as "British Chinese"—who adopt a flexible identity that transcends the hyphen.

Ng's hybridity is further reflected in the novel's fictionalised account of East Timor's founding, portrayed through the miserable experience of Danu's decolonisation. While problematising the political attribution of a serious role in national self-definition that is primarily tied to masculinity,[66] Mo ironically rationalises Ng's transformation from a participant in Danu's struggle for independence to an accomplice in the *malai* recolonisation project. Ng's betrayal directs his national and sexual hybridity to Homi K. Bhabha's insight, "the sign of the productivity of colonial power".[67] However, as hybridity also allows "the strategic reversal of the process of domination through disavowal",[68] Ng publicises his inglorious story, after being freed by the *malais*, to make heard the voice of a twice-colonised nation, endangered by capitalist expansion. Moreover, by acquiring a Brazilian passport that addresses him by a Japanese surname, Ng chooses a place that shares with Danu the experience of Portuguese colonisation, suggesting that his cosmopolitan and homosexual identities hold potential for new ways of building the nation. Despite acknowledging that "[a]n identity and a history cannot be obliterated with a switch of a name or the stroke of a pen",[69] Ng's behaviour appears as an act of redundant courage to cast off his past. Ng's moral inconsistency, which has led to him being blamed for "the most negative representation of Chineseness",[70] is mirrored by Mo's own ambivalence towards the character. He even confessed: "He's like a rat, continually resurfacing after the dust has settled. He's my nightmare of what I might be."[71] This discomfort not only reflects Mo's uneasy literary experiment, motivated by a pursuit of global justice rather than ethnic or national allegiance, but also casts the shadow of Cold War geopolitical legacies over Anglophone writers who are, in some way, associated with a Chinese lineage.

From projecting postcolonial concerns about the fate of a particular ethnic minority to incorporating international affairs into his cosmopolitan narrative, Mo displays a writerly

[64]Ibid.
[65]Hall, "Cultural Identity and Diaspora," 222.
[66]Hawley, "The Role of Sexuality in Nation-Building," 123.
[67]Bhabha, *The Location of Culture*, 112.
[68]Ibid., 112.
[69]Mo, *The Redundancy of Courage*, 446.
[70]Ruan, Zhang, and Li, *Yingguo Kuawenhua Xiaozhuo Zhong De Shenfen Cuoluan*, 263.
[71]Pullinger, "Creating a Hero of Our Times," 7.

competence in addressing topical issues. His thematic shift coincides with the end of the Cold War, since which writers from mainland China have been active again in the British cultural landscape, and the literary identity of "British Chinese" has become gradually luxuriant. On the one hand, shaped by the ideological legacy of dichotomy, late twentieth-century British Chinese narratives, including those by Jung Chang and Ying Hong, often depict a disordered and grotesque image of Chineseness, aligning with Mo's strategy of self-exoticisation to accommodate Western perceptions of Maoist China. On the other hand, works produced in the twenty-first century by authors such as Hong Liu and Xiaolu Guo tend to rearticulate the inclusiveness and heterogeneity embedded in the notion of Chineseness, continuing Mo's efforts to expand the discursive space of his writing. Meanwhile, with the rapid movement across countries in the age of globalisation, Mo deterritorialises both Chinese ethnicity and British nationality in his later career, structuring the Asian experience in response to neo-colonialism and neo-imperialism.

Reconstituting Asian Subjectivity

> I was a man, that was my primary visible tribe, but I was also underdog by birth and by temperament. That was my real tribe, that was the despised outsiders, trying to get in from the cold.[72]

As Ng's varied identities are established by the legacy and extension of colonialism, this hybridity is disputed by Kuan-Hsing Chen as "a product of the colonial machine's efforts toward assimilation".[73] It impacts the constitution of Ng's subjectivity by depriving it of the autonomy that becomes crucial in Mo's later attempt to position Asia against hegemonic globalisation. Regarding the Asian region's decolonisation and deimperialisation, Chen argues that autonomous subjectivity grows out of an improved version of hybridity, namely "syncretism", where "a subject who is highly self-conscious when translating the limits of the self" transcends them through reflexive interaction with various groups.[74] In practice, the West should no longer be Asia's only subject of identification, a role it occupied during earlier periods when the Europe-oriented modernisation discourse dominated the region. This is embodied in *Brownout on Breadfruit Boulevard*, which posits that Philippine development should not imitate the politics of modernisation of its former colonisers. Instead, a "critical syncretism" presupposes a diversified selection for the self, especially for the subaltern, "to become others"[75] in order to decentre colonial power. This is similar to Mo's interiorisation of elements from minority groups, regardless of ethnicity or hierarchy, into the subjectivity of the self in *Renegade or Halo*^{2} and *Pure*, thereby deterritorialising the obvious boundaries constructed by Western-centric discourse. The multiracial Castro and the transgender Snooky are not anxious about being "others", and they critically syncretise the hegemonic culture to develop their subjectivity as English-speaking Asians. Given that existing scholarship on "Asian Englishes" pays close attention to the interaction between the "functional nativeness"[76] of English

[72]Mo, *Renegade or Halo*^{2}, 190.
[73]Chen, *Asia as Method*, 98.
[74]Ibid. Despite designating minorities of predominantly South Asian descent in Britain, the term "Asian" focuses on East and Southeast Asia in Chen's context, due to his Taiwanese identity and American educational experience; the same has been retained in this article.
[75]Ibid., 99.
[76]Kachru, *Asian Englishes*, 25.

and the negotiability of Asian identities, Mo connects them through a developed version of Gideon's cosmopolitanism. It not only severs the absolute link between language and national belonging, but also detaches globalised English from its exploitative and domesticating ideology for addressing others, endowing his later protagonists with an autonomous but nonexclusive Asian subjectivity.

Brownout on Breadfruit Boulevard and *Renegade or Halo*^{2}, in line with his experience in Southeast Asia, explore the Philippines' encounter with the postcolonial world. Yet, the Philippines does not perform any territorialised function of the state apparatus but epitomises an underdeveloped Asian country that is at the mercy of the uneven forces of globalisation. The former is written from the third-person perspective of the Philippine scholar, Mr. Boyet, and his patron, Mrs. Init, who collude in holding an international conference to appease capitalist hegemony, signifying the country's disempowerment. The latter, narrated in the first person, centres on Rey Castro—a mixed-race man born to an African American sailor and a Chinese Philippine bar girl—and his life as an undocumented migrant worker. Mo's exposure of neoliberal capitalism's uneven distribution and exploitation of labour, from which no race or ethnicity is exempt, reflects a significant transformation in his career. By criticising tribalism and expressing strong moral and political sympathies, he shows a cosmopolitan openness that illustrates a "new and different way of conceiving human relationships".[77] However, his bravura is not well-received by readers who recognise Mo's works as depicting his ethnic origin; combined with the inadequate copyediting and publicity of both novels, his self-publishing is branded as "damned".[78] His crisis in the marketplace offers minority authors a lesson in maintaining readership and competitiveness, especially those who seek to produce literature beyond ethnicity.

Mrs. Init chooses Gobernador de Leon as her conference venue. This fictional site is "not at all representative of the country as a whole, like an ornamental garden in the middle of the Gobi".[79] Managed by her quasi-Marcos family, this city is expected to be internationally (read: occidentally) recognised as a landmark in the modernisation of the Philippines. Yet, the only thing common among the foreign attendees is that "no one seemed to know much about the country they were in".[80] Moreover, its emergency "brownout", followed by a bombing in the convention centre, left a ridiculous impression on them. This stark contrast, while ironising Mrs. Init's partial correlation of Westernisation with modernisation, also indicates the Philippines' need to explore its own development path, especially after the collapse of the corrupt Marcos regime (1965–1986). The satirical account of political unrest and social upheaval in the Philippines resonates with the theme addressed in Jessica Hagedorn's *Dogeaters* (1990), which similarly critiques the Marcos dictatorship. Mo's implicit dialogue with broader Asian American literature enriches our understanding of his work beyond the literal sense of "British Chinese", situating his contribution to wider Asian diasporic narratives.

Castro further reveals the difficulty of reconstituting Filipino subjectivity due to its long history of Spanish and American occupation: "Three hundred years of Torquemada and fifty of Loony Tunes—man, we had no idea who we were any

[77]Said, *The World, the Text, and the Critic*, 17.
[78]Lezard, "Self-Publish and Be Damned."
[79]Mo, *Brownout on Breadfruit Boulevard*, 26.
[80]Ibid., 214.

more."[81] Sharing Ng's hybridity but differing from his ambiguity, Castro sees himself as "halo^2", or halo-halo in its complete form, a typical native dessert with "a whole bunch of ingredients that shouldn't belong together but work when you combine them",[82] which invokes thematic rhetoric. As a metaphor for syncretism, Castro's identity formation is free from any imaginary "other"; it is the cosmopolitan identification of "man" as the basic tribal unit, crystallised in the opening section of his manifesto on non-discrimination. Through this figure, Mo's writing tentatively delineates a pan-Asian, cross-ethnic subjectivity—one that does not erase but rather coexists with Castro's American heritage, Black identity, and diasporic trajectory—to be compatible with global diasporas like him of mixed descent and multiple migrations. Regrettably, the resistance to tribalism threatens the sense of belonging to existing communities that are constituted through racial exclusion and organised according to internal hierarchies. The title reminds us that Castro's perspective is that of a "renegade" who is not accepted by his own tribe, being framed for murder and living in exile as a "contemporary picaro".[83] Yet, both the character's and the author's embrace of the renegade position illustrates cosmopolitanism's defiant stance against essentialist identities.

The picaro, originating from the dramatic descriptions of forcibly converted Jews in sixteenth-century Spanish satire, has evolved into a literary archetype that simultaneously embodies conformity and subversion by observing the underclass and critiquing the upper class. In Mo's global context, migrant labour is its incarnate form, characterised by "the utmost precariousness",[84] in order to insinuate the hypocrisy common to the privileged in both the East and West. While Castro's picaresque adventure unfolds via ship—the preferred means of transport for those on the bottom rung of international migration, it is also the mode used by Evergreen, Boyet's employer, to freight toxic waste from Germany to the Philippines as a secret condition of the former's financial support. The linkage between Castro's poor quality of life and his country's fortune in being turned into a dumping ground highlights Asia's dilemma in managing globalisation, which has been deliberately ignored by Western profit-seekers. It was only when the 2000 Dover smuggling tragedy, the 2004 Morecambe Bay cockling disaster, and the 2019 Essex lorry deaths caught the British public eye that mainstream media began reporting on international illegal workers. Lending voice to this disempowered group beforehand proves Mo's keen literary foresight, as he holds that "there'll be more halo-halos like [him]self", in reply to the criticism that his radical cosmopolitan theme "do[es]n't have a natural readership".[85] Indeed, the plight of Asian/Chinese illegal workers in Britain recurs in the London-based Taiwanese author Hsiao-Hung Pai's documentary writing *Chinese Whispers* (2008), which negotiates with the majority discourse to disclose the unequal movement of population in the current globalising world. The extension of Mo's dedication to marginalised subjects elucidates his role in diversifying British Chinese literature and raising heterogeneous

[81]Mo, *Renegade or Halo^2*, 31.
[82]Ibid., 261.
[83]Finney, "Migrancy and the Picaresque in Timothy Mo's *Renegade or Halo^2*," 74.
[84]Elze, *Postcolonial Modernism and the Picaresque Novel*, 1.
[85]Jaggi, "Mixtures like Candied Napalm."

voices in opposition to the Anglophone market's hidden attempt at covering minority groups' internal differences with an ethnic label.

Mo's subsequent decade-plus silence gives him ample time to update his subject matter in *Pure*, featuring a transgender character—referred to in the novel by the contested term "ladyboy", commonly used in Thai contexts—who is born into a Thai Muslim family and becomes a disciple of Southeast Asian English. The performance of a gendered body, oscillating between masculinity and femininity, offers a compelling instance of Judith Butler's claim that identity "has no ontological status apart from the various acts which constitute its reality".[86] Annoyed by his/her religious name, Ahmed, the protagonist renames himself/herself as Snooky, the English variant of the Thai word *sanook*, meaning "fun"; concurrently, he/she retains the Siamese habit of referring to himself/herself in the third person, denying the dominance of English language in the Asian context. The intentional misuse of English illustrates the influence of competing discursive modes and the destabilisation of assumed cultural hierarchies. This is Mo's move ahead of responding to the Empire by writing in CPE, which, while inversing the power relation, also strengthens the centre-periphery opposition. By placing Snooky in the interstitiality between Islamisation and Westernisation/modernisation, and between Asianness and Englishness, Mo continues his cosmopolitan literary practice that disengages him from the territory charted by nationality and ethnicity.

The deterritorialisation of identity reaches its peak with Snooky's self-deprecating comment on his/her existence: "The sum of me has never equalled my hopes."[87] Distancing himself/herself from the language and faith bound up with his/her family of origin, this rebellious character reproduces the ethnic non-homogeneity, previously explored in the Chinese diaspora, among Thai Muslims. Given his/her ongoing engagement in the process of becoming rather than alienating others, Snooky's subjectivity construction echoes Castro's critical syncretism of diverse tribes, races, and nations. By emphasising Snooky's double resistance to territorialised Muslim and hegemonic English, Mo unfolds the corresponding post-9/11 opposition between political Islam and the West. The ironic title symbolises both sides' delusion of purifying Snooky; instead, inspired by his/her "cosmopolitanised" subjectivity,[88] he/she always serves as the "parodist, inverter, homage-payer, and satirist"[89] that counterbalances them. Unlike the misfit Ng, Snooky benefits from his/her multiple identities, which enable him/her to fit in the multicultural Southeast Asia. Snooky's characterisation thus reflects Mo's incorporation of "impurity" into Asian subjectivity, empathising with the post-9/11 transnational political ideal of different communities setting aside their sectarian interests to wipe out terrorism.

Mo's thematic shift to the cosmopolitan ideal, which once failed in multicultural marketing, has since revitalised scholarship on British Chinese literature in the wake of the growing market demand for "diversity". In other words, Mo's mixed reputation foreshadows a current tension in publishing between the expectation of minority writers to create what "relat[e] to their racial or ethnic identity" and the "fear that such stories might appear too niche".[90] Under the circumstances, Mo's denationalised and pan-

[86]Butler, *Gender Trouble*, 136.
[87]Mo, *Pure*, 7.
[88]Ibid., 8.
[89]Ibid., 72.
[90]Saha and Van Lente, "The Limits of Diversity," 1817.

ethnic narrative goes beyond the niche and allies with later UK-published writers of Chinese ancestry in expanding the boundaries of their literature. With the temporal and spatial expansion in the context of British colonisation, Mo's exploration of the Chinese diaspora's multivalent dimensions echoes not only Tash Aw's delineation of British Malaya's Peranakan Chinese world in *The Harmony Silk Factory* (2005), but also Kerry Young's depiction of postcolonial Jamaica's creolised Chinese community in *Pao* (2011). These resonances suggest Mo's success in de-dualising "British Chinese" and positioning himself in a wider context while being internationally visible for his writing on Southeast Asia. Open to interpretations from disparate sociocultural perspectives, Mo's writings outside the confines of Britain and China thus function as a critical medium for tracing the dynamics of British Chinese literature within the global Anglophone context.

Conclusion

Through the contextualisation of Mo's writing style in the diachronic and synchronic shift from postcolonialism to cosmopolitanism in those UK-published literary works by ethnic Chinese authors, this article uses Mo's career as a lens through which to examine the broader evolution of British Chinese literature across a century. On the one hand, the alienated representations of Chineseness in his early works not only illustrate the strategic exoticism of postcolonial writers but also mirror the Cold War's impediment to the cross-cultural interaction between Britain and China. On the other hand, Mo's visibility is inseparable from the prevalence of multiculturalism in British society; his involvement in and reflections on this mark British Chinese literature's progress from spontaneous to self-conscious development. Though his expanding map of Asian diasporas that transcends the binarily-constrained "British Chinese" was once not appreciated, the recurrences of his later themes in international English-language literature have demonstrated an inexorable trend towards worldlisation among the literary discourses labelled "ethnic".

As Elaine Yee Lin Ho concludes in the only monograph on Mo to date, the chief reason for the relative critical neglect of Mo is that "a writer like him does not fit readily into existing academic categories or fields of study".[91] This remark not only throws light on the limitations of academic categorisation but also implicitly prompts a reconsideration or contestation of disciplinary boundaries over time, in parallel with an examination of the development of their potential components. While Mo's writings cannot easily be assigned to any single nation-state or ethnic group, the term "British Chinese" is increasingly cosmopolitanised as an open discourse, inclusive of diverse cultural backgrounds and multiple diasporic identities. The correspondence between Mo's thematic shift and the deterritorialisation of British Chinese literature is not incompatible with an interpretive perspective grounded in transnational Asian literary conversation. Given the tension between the hyphenated conceptualisation of minority authors and their wider boundary-crossing transactions in twenty-first-century geopolitics, an anti-essentialist view of both "Chinese" and other "ethnic" voices is necessary. This applies not only in the British multicultural literary scene but also in the changing landscape of world literature.

[91]Ho, *Timothy Mo*, 144.

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ORCID

Yifan Jin http://orcid.org/0000-0002-1953-8340

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